

**ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026**

# Corporate Strategy English

## Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

### **PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK**

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For corporate strategy, CEO office, transformation, corporate development, strategic finance, product strategy, and internal consulting teams.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

# Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

## **01 Strategy Role, Problem Framing, and Executive Diagnosis**

Clarify missing information before responding.

## **02 Strategic Choices: Ambition, Where to Play, How to Win, and Tradeoffs**

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

## **03 Industry Structure, Competitive Dynamics, and Profit Pools**

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

## **04 Business Models, Unit Economics, Capabilities, and Advantage**

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

## **05 Portfolio Strategy, Capital Allocation, and Resource Reallocation**

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

## **06 Growth Strategy, Market Entry, Partnerships, and M&A Logic**

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

## **07 Uncertainty, Scenarios, Strategic Options, and Risk Posture**

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

## **08 Execution Governance, Operating Model, KPIs, and Board Narrative**

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

## **Choose your pace**

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one case and saying a response. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, conversation, writing, and revision.

## **Level support**

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop, or use the prompts at the end of this guide.

# A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

## **0-5 minutes | Activate experience**

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

## **5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts**

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

## **12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language**

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

## **22-35 minutes | Speak and respond**

Give two minutes of preparation. Run the partner exchange, switch roles, and add the follow-up challenge. Observe whether the listener can act on the message.

## **35-47 minutes | Write for a real reader**

Learners write the short message using only case facts. Partners check clarity, certainty, and the requested next step.

## **47-55 minutes | Compare and revise**

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

## **55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer**

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

## **Adapt the session**

For 45 minutes, shorten the first conversation and assign writing for follow-up. For 90 minutes, add 15 minutes for a second case and 15 minutes for the final challenge. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

## LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

# Strategy Role, Problem Framing, and Executive Diagnosis

Clarify missing information before responding.

**CASE**

An executive asks for a "growth strategy" but has not specified whether the priority is revenue, profit, or market entry.

**Teach this move**

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: Diagnosis, Ambition, Strategic thesis, Issue tree.

**Model response**

Which outcome are we trying to improve, over what period? Revenue growth, profit improvement, and entry into a new market may require different choices. Let's define the decision first.

**Listen for, then coach**

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: what this means.

**Second-round challenge**

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

**Language-check answers**

1. B - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: the review starts.
2. A - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

## LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

# Strategic Choices: Ambition, Where to Play, How to Win, and Tradeoffs

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

**CASE**

A team can invest in its core service or enter a new segment. The same staff would support both, and capacity is limited.

**Teach this move**

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Vocabulary to check: Strategic choice, Tradeoff, Activity system, Opportunity cost.

**Model response**

The two options compete for the same team. Expanding the core uses existing capabilities; entering the segment requires new ones. We should make the resource tradeoff explicit before selecting a direction.

**Listen for, then coach**

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. 'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

**Second-round challenge**

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

**Language-check answers**

1. A - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less. 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.
2. C - An increase of one percentage point. Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

## LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

# Industry Structure, Competitive Dynamics, and Profit Pools

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

**CASE**

A market estimate is based on total industry spending, but the company can serve only one customer segment.

**Teach this move**

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: TAM, SAM, SOM, Profit pool.

**Model response**

Total industry spending is broader than our addressable opportunity. I'll separate the overall market from the segment we can serve and explain the assumptions used to estimate our potential share.

**Listen for, then coach**

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

**Second-round challenge**

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

**Language-check answers**

1. C - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. B - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

## LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

# Business Models, Unit Economics, Capabilities, and Advantage

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

**CASE**

A new service has positive revenue growth but negative contribution after variable delivery costs. A slide calls growth proof of a sound business model.

**Teach this move**

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: Value driver, ROIC, Margin expansion, Right to win.

**Model response**

Growth shows demand, but it does not by itself demonstrate attractive unit economics. Let's explain the revenue and variable costs per unit before drawing conclusions about the model.

**Listen for, then coach**

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

**Second-round challenge**

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

**Language-check answers**

1. B - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. A - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

## LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

# Portfolio Strategy, Capital Allocation, and Resource Reallocation

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

**CASE**

Two divisions request the same investment budget. Neither proposal explains what work would stop if it were funded.

**Teach this move**

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Vocabulary to check: Capital allocation, Core business, Divestiture, Adjacency.

**Model response**

Could each division identify the expected benefit, key assumption, and activity it would deprioritize? That would let us compare the proposals as allocation choices rather than separate wish lists.

**Listen for, then coach**

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. For an ordinary future condition, the if-clause uses present tense. The other clause can express the future consequence or possibility.

**Second-round challenge**

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

**Language-check answers**

1. A - If the scope changes, we will review the schedule. The if-clause uses present tense; the main clause states the future response.
2. C - We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope. This offers a useful next step while keeping the approval and scope question open.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

## LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

# Growth Strategy, Market Entry, Partnerships, and M&A Logic

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

**CASE**

An acquisition proposal lists possible cost savings. No integration plan or implementation estimate has been prepared.

**Teach this move**

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: Market entry, Build-buy-partner, Synergy, PMI.

**Model response**

These are potential synergies, not confirmed savings. I'll distinguish the opportunity from the work and cost required to achieve it so the proposal presents a balanced strategic case.

**Listen for, then coach**

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

**Second-round challenge**

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

**Language-check answers**

1. C - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. B - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

## LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

# Uncertainty, Scenarios, Strategic Options, and Risk Posture

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

**CASE**

A planning workshop has a base case and a downside case. The team wants to call one a prediction.

**Teach this move**

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Vocabulary to check: Scenario planning, Residual uncertainty, Trigger indicator, Strategic option.

**Model response**

These scenarios explore different conditions; neither is a promise about the future. Let's identify the signals we would monitor and which decisions we would revisit if conditions changed.

**Listen for, then coach**

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. 'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

**Second-round challenge**

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

**Language-check answers**

1. B - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less. 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.
2. A - An increase of one percentage point. Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

## LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

# Execution Governance, Operating Model, KPIs, and Board Narrative

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

**CASE**

A board presentation has twelve metrics but no clear request. The sponsor needs approval for a limited pilot.

**Teach this move**

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Vocabulary to check: Operating model, Decision rights, KPI, Board narrative.

**Model response**

The decision today is whether to authorize the pilot. I'll lead with that request, the proposed scope, and the measures for reviewing it, then use the remaining metrics as supporting detail.

**Listen for, then coach**

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised question gives people a way to raise a concern. Silence can have several meanings, especially in unfamiliar or unequal-power situations.

**Second-round challenge**

A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

**Language-check answers**

1. A - We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view? It invites participation without interpreting silence as consent.
2. C - Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options. This distinguishes discussion from approval and identifies the next reviewer.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

# Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

## Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

## Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

## Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

## Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

## Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

## Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

## Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

# Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

## Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

## Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

### Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

### Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

## Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

# Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

## Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

## Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

## Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

## Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

# Adapt a partner or class activity

## START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

## REFERENCE

Course: Corporate Strategy English

Professional audience: corporate strategy, CEO office, transformation, corporate development, strategic finance, product strategy, and internal consulting teams

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Strategy Role, Problem Framing, and Executive Diagnosis

Original fictional case: An executive asks for a "growth strategy" but has not specified whether the priority is revenue, profit, or market entry.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is ... . Is that right?

Vocabulary: Diagnosis: Explanation of the strategic problem, its cause, and why it matters now. / Ambition: High-level performance or market position the company wants to achieve. / Strategic thesis: Argument for why a course of action should create advantage or value. / Issue tree: Structured breakdown of a problem into analyzable questions.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and

an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Which outcome are we trying to improve, over what period? Revenue growth, profit improvement, and entry into a new market may require different choices. Let's define the decision first.

#### END REFERENCE

TASK: Adapt this material for a teaching session

1. Ask me one brief planning question covering learner support needs, group size and available time. Offer a default of two B2 learners and 20 minutes. Stop and wait; use the default only if I choose it.
2. Create a timed plan using the supplied case or dialogue, its actual terminology and one narrow language goal. Include an individual first attempt, partner exchange, focused feedback and a retry. Keep the total within the time I choose. State what the learner should be able to communicate at the end.
3. Provide separate role cards for two or three professional speakers. Each card needs an objective, known information and one question to resolve. Label any invented private information as a variation; do not contradict shared facts. Do not place the model answer on the learner cards.
4. Add a B1 support option with useful frames, a B2 independent task and a C1 extension involving a plausible competing constraint. Maintain the same professional meaning across levels. Explain unfamiliar terms without removing the field's normal language. Include a workable solo alternative.
5. Put teacher notes and suggested responses in a clearly separate section after the learner material. Include likely misunderstandings and a short observation checklist for facts, clarity, tone and next step. Accept multiple successful formulations. Finish with one exit question and a delayed-recall task; identify what the teacher should check before use.

#### END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

# Adjust tone and register

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Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

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Vocabulary: Diagnosis: Explanation of the strategic problem, its cause, and why it matters now. / Ambition: High-level performance or market position the company wants to achieve. / Strategic thesis: Argument for why a course of action should create advantage or value. / Issue tree: Structured breakdown of a problem into analyzable questions.

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Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

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an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Which outcome are we trying to improve, over what period? Revenue growth, profit improvement, and entry into a new market may require different choices. Let's define the decision first.

**END REFERENCE**

**TASK:** Match the language to the listener

1. Choose a short message or utterance from the reference and quote it exactly. Identify its purpose and likely audience. Ask me to choose a new audience: a close colleague, a decision-maker, or an external reader who may not know the jargon. Stop and wait.
2. Ask me to adapt that message for the chosen reader, keeping its facts and degree of certainty unchanged. Offer a short frame only if I request help. Wait for my attempt before showing alternatives.
3. Discuss at most three choices in my version: directness, specialist vocabulary and interpersonal tone. Explain when a direct request is clearer than extra politeness, and when an unfamiliar abbreviation needs expansion. Avoid cultural stereotypes or claims that one nationality always communicates a certain way.
4. Show two natural alternatives, such as a concise spoken version and a more explicit written version. Explain the tradeoff in each. Do not turn a request into an order, a possibility into a promise, or a pending decision into approval.
5. Ask me to respond to one realistic follow-up from the new reader, then wait. Finish by asking me to adapt the message for a second audience without losing its core meaning. Give feedback only after the attempt.

**END PROMPT**

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level